THEN VS NOW

The Shop Window

What the Old Window Dressers Knew About Websites and Landing Pages



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THE SHOP WINDOW

What the Old Window Dressers Knew About Websites and Landing Pages

Seven classic principles of window display, quoted from the originals and rebuilt for the internet.

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First published 2026

Website: GetFreeEbooks.com

A Note from the Publisher

In 1900 a shop window was the only part of a business that a stranger saw without being asked. People walked past it at a steady pace, glanced for a second or two, and either stopped or kept walking. The men who dressed those windows had no heatmaps and no analytics, only the pavement outside and the till at the end of the week, and they learned from both.

This book takes their advice to the screen. Each chapter quotes a window dresser or printer from the early twentieth century on one principle of display, then shows where it applies now: the top of a landing page, a product photo, a pricing table, a home page on the first day of a sale.

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Published by GetFreeEbooks

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First Edition, 2026

A note on process: this book was assembled with offline software from public domain source material, then reviewed before publication.

Acknowledgements

Thank you to the generations of writers, editors and volunteers who kept these works alive long enough for them to reach the public domain — and to everyone who digitised, proofread and preserved them since.

This book is published through GetFreeEbooks, a platform built on a simple idea: that good books should be easy to find, and free to read. Thank you to that community of readers and writers for giving books like this one a place to land.

Quick Start Summary

Each chapter in this book takes one principle from the old window dressers and printers, quotes them in their own words, and translates the idea for the internet. Here is the whole book at a glance:

- **Catch Your Hare First** — Earn the first few seconds, then use them to show what you sell. *(Still true — use it as written)*
- **Fewer Things, Better Shown** — Show fewer things, and give each one room. *(More important now than it was then)*
- **Pretty Is Not the Point** — A page is good if it sells and reads easily; looking good is a bonus. *(More important now than it was then)*
- **Let the Goods Tell a Story** — Show the product being used, not just the product. *(Still true — but the channel has changed)*
- **Where the Eye Lands First** — Decide what visitors see first, and make everything else quieter. *(Still true — but the channel has changed)*
- **Somebody Always Notices** — Small flaws cost trust, and trust is what the page is selling. *(More important now than it was then)*
- **What Goes in the Window** — Give your best space to what is new or what must go, and change it with the season. *(Still true — but the channel has changed)*

Chapter 1: Catch Your Hare First

A window dresser had a few seconds to stop someone who was on the way to somewhere else. The best of them treated those seconds as the whole job, because goods that nobody stopped to look at could not sell, however good they were. Writing in *The Art of Decorating Dry Goods Windows and Interiors* (1900), L. Frank Baum observed:

> *Shrewd and observant trimmers have found that the secret of successful windows is to have a background or mechanical device that will command attention, and then to place the goods in so ingenious a manner that in looking at the display people note the excellence of the goods and desire to purchase them. It's the old idea of first catching your hare and then cooking it. But you must catch your hare. You must have an attraction that induces the pedestrian to stop and look, or your window is a flat failure. That is why beautiful, artistic and mechanical displays are to be encouraged rather than discouraged. These are the real "business windows."*
>
> *— L. Frank Baum, The Art of Decorating Dry Goods Windows and Interiors (1900)*

What It Means Now

On a website the pavement is the top of the page, the part a visitor sees before scrolling. That space has to do what Baum's background did: give a reason to stay long enough to see what is for sale. A headline that names the visitor's problem, one clear image and a single obvious next step usually do more there than a slideshow of rotating banners.

The second half of the advice matters as much as the first. Once the visitor has stopped, the page has to show the goods well enough that they want them. A striking top section followed by a vague, crowded page is a hare caught and then left uncooked.

Then	Now
The mechanical window display	The top of the landing page, above the fold
The pedestrian walking past	The visitor scrolling past in a search result or feed
Goods placed so their quality shows	Product detail directly below the headline

In Practice: The top of a bakery's order page

Before: A full-width photo of the shop front and the words "Welcome to Hartley's Bakery, family run for three generations."

After: "Birthday cakes delivered across Leeds. Order by 2pm for tomorrow." above a photo of

one cake and an Order button.

The first version tells the visitor who you are. The second tells them whether you can help, which is the only thing they stopped to find out.

The Verdict: Still true — use it as written

A century of new media has not dented this one. It was sound advice then, and it is sound advice now.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Earn the first few seconds, then use them to show what you sell.*

Try This

- Open your main page on a phone and note what is visible before you scroll
- Rewrite the top headline so it names the visitor's problem, not your company
- Remove any rotating banner and keep its single strongest slide

Chapter 2: Fewer Things, Better Shown

Every generation of shopkeepers has been tempted to put the whole stock in the window, on the theory that more goods means more chances of a sale. The men who wrote about window dressing spent a surprising amount of ink arguing against it. Here is how L. Frank Baum put it in *The Art of Decorating Dry Goods Windows and Interiors* (1900):

> *Interior display should be simple, harmonious, artistic. Don't attempt to bewilder your customers. A woman in search of an apron shies from a great bunch of aprons swung from the ceiling, but is attracted by a single apron tastefully displayed. So it is with all goods.*
>
> *— L. Frank Baum, The Art of Decorating Dry Goods Windows and Interiors (1900)*

What It Means Now

Web pages crowd for the same reason windows did. Every department wants its product on the home page, every feature gets a paragraph, and the result is a page where nothing stands out. A visitor faced with twelve equal options often picks none of them and leaves, and analytics records the loss as the bounce rate.

The fix is the one Baum gave: choose a few things and show them properly. A landing page built around one product, with one call to action, gives the visitor a single decision to make. Everything else can live one click away.

Then	Now
Crowding the window	A home page with a dozen equal tiles
A single apron, tastefully displayed	One featured product with room around it
The shopper who shies away	The visitor who bounces

In Practice: A gift shop's home page

Before: Twelve product tiles of equal size, a newsletter box, three banners and a chat pop-up.

After: One seasonal product with a large photo, a price and a Buy button, then three categories below it.

Nothing was removed from the shop, only from the first screen. Visitors who wanted the other nine products could still find them.

The Verdict: More important now than it was then

The stakes have risen since this was written. What was once an edge is now the minimum a reader expects.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Show fewer things, and give each one room.*

Try This

- Count the separate links and buttons on your home page, then cut the number by a third
- Pick one product to feature this month and give it the top of the page
- Add white space around your main button

Chapter 3: Pretty Is Not the Point

Around 1900, window dressing and commercial printing were both turning into arts, each with its own trade journals and its own experts. The practical writers in both trades never forgot what the work was for, and they said so bluntly. Edmund G. Gress described it this way in *The Art & Practice of Typography* (1917):

> *The first requirement of typography is that it shall be easy to read; the second is that it shall be good to look at. The efficient typographer studies the copy and arranges it so that the reader's task is an easy and pleasant one.*
>
> *— Edmund G. Gress, The Art & Practice of Typography (1917)*

What It Means Now

Design awards and portfolio sites reward pages that look striking in a screenshot. Customers reward pages that make buying easy. The two overlap less often than designers would like, and a full-screen video, a clever scrolling effect or a pale grey font can win praise and still lose sales.

Judge every design choice by one question: does this help the visitor understand the offer and act on it? If it does, keep it, however plain. If it does not, cut it, however pretty. A readable font size, strong contrast and a button that looks like a button are unglamorous, and they are what the conversion rate rewards.

Then	Now
The "picture window"	The admired page that does not convert
Goods sold, not merely shown	Conversion rate as the measure of design
Easy to read first, good to look at second	Font size, contrast and plain buttons

In Practice: A course sales page

Before: A dark page with thin grey text laid over a looping background video.

After: Black text on white at 18 pixels, with the video moved below the price as an optional preview.

The video stayed. It just stopped standing between the reader and the words that explain what they are buying.

The Verdict: More important now than it was then

Online, this principle carries more weight than it did in its own day. Every weakness it guards against is now exposed faster and to more people.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *A page is good if it sells and reads easily; looking good is a bonus.*

Try This

- Check that your body text is at least 16 pixels on a phone
- Run your text and background colours through a free contrast checker
- Ask someone who has never seen the page to find the price and the buy button, and time them

Chapter 4: Let the Goods Tell a Story

Stacking a bolt of cloth in a window proved that the shop had cloth. The better window dressers and catalogue printers wanted more from the same material: an arrangement or a picture that showed what the goods were for and left the customer imagining them in use. In *The Art & Practice of Typography* (1917), Edmund G. Gress wrote:

> *In commercial catalog work the illustration of the article to be sold is of the same importance as the article on the counter in the salesroom. The usual method of selling is to show the customer the article and then by giving information about it and telling of its good qualities to persuade the customer to buy.*
>
> *— Edmund G. Gress, The Art & Practice of Typography (1917)*

What It Means Now

Online, the bolt of cloth is the product photo on a white background. Buyers need it, because they want to see exactly what they will get, but on its own it is the weak advertisement the old dressers complained about. The stronger picture shows the product in use: the jacket on someone walking in the rain, the software screen with real figures in it, the tent pitched with its door open.

Short demonstration videos, customer photos and before-and-after images all do the draping the old trimmers recommended. They turn an object into a picture of the buyer's own life with the object in it, and that picture is what people remember when they come back to buy.

Then	Now
A bolt of goods on display	Product shots on a white background
Goods draped to mean something	Lifestyle photos and demonstration videos
The catalogue picture as the article on the counter	Product images that carry the sale

In Practice: A handmade mug listing

Before: Three photos of the mug on white, from the front, the side and above.

After: The same three, plus one of the mug on a cluttered desk beside a laptop at seven in the morning, steam rising.

Buyers still need the plain shots to judge size and colour. The fourth photo is the one that sells the morning.

The Verdict: Still true — but the channel has changed

The goal is the same as it ever was; only the route to the customer has changed.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Show the product being used, not just the product.*

Try This

- For your best-selling product, add one photo of it in use
- Record a phone video, under a minute long, of the product doing its main job
- Ask three customers for a photo of the product in their home or workplace

Chapter 5: Where the Eye Lands First

A window is a picture with a frame, and the dressers knew that the eye does not wander over a picture at random. They planned where the weight of a display sat, and printers of the same period applied the same thinking to a page of type. Edmund G. Gress set it down in *The Art & Practice of Typography* (1917):

> *An initial has other duties to perform than merely to look pretty; it must direct the eye to the beginning of the reading matter. In the manuscript books of the Middle Ages, written without paragraphs, the starting point of a new thought was denoted by an initial more or less elaborate. The utilitarian purpose thus served by the initial is reason for making it a trifle darker than the remainder of the page. However, if there is great contrast in tone, the page will be difficult to read because of the initial claiming too much attention. The effect would be much like attempting to listen to one speaker while another is calling and beckoning.*
>
> *— Edmund G. Gress, The Art & Practice of Typography (1917)*

What It Means Now

Designers call it visual hierarchy: the order in which a visitor notices things. Size, colour, contrast and space decide it long before anyone reads a word. If the logo, the menu, a cookie banner and the headline all compete at the same strength, the eye jumps between them and settles on none.

Decide what the visitor should see first, second and third, and make each one quieter than the one before. The headline is heaviest. The button comes next, in the only strong colour on the page. Everything else, the menu included, steps back. Printers of the period warned against a decorative initial letter that drew more attention than the text it opened, and the warning applies to any element that shouts louder than its message.

Then	Now
The heaviest part of the trim in the centre	The headline as the heaviest element on the page
A background as the frame of the picture	Space and contrast around the main offer
An initial that directs the eye	A button that stands out from everything else

In Practice: A webinar sign-up page

Before: Logo, menu, headline, date and button all in bold, with the button in the same blue as the menu.

After: A large headline, the date in plain type beneath it, and the only orange on the page used

for the Register button.

Nothing new was added. The page got easier to read by making most of it quieter.

The Verdict: Still true — but the channel has changed

Keep the thinking and update the equipment: the tools of the period have been replaced, but the reasoning behind them has not.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Decide what visitors see first, and make everything else quieter.*

Try This

- Blur a screenshot of your page and note the first three shapes you notice
- Use your strongest colour for one thing only: the main button
- Shrink or soften anything that competes with the headline

Chapter 6: Somebody Always Notices

The window dresser who left a pin showing or a price card crooked could tell himself that nobody would see it. The men who trained window dressers knew that the people who stop to look closely are exactly the ones who notice. L. Frank Baum made the point in *The Art of Decorating Dry Goods Windows and Interiors* (1900):

> *I have had a great deal of experience with window trimmers, and have found that the great majority of them do not pay that strict attention to detail which is so necessary in a perfectly dressed window. They will say, "Oh, that is good enough," "No one will notice that," etc., when they detect some omission in the detail of the work. But they are wrong, for a great many of those whose attention is attracted to the display will as quickly note the defect as the skilled window trimmer himself.*
>
> *— L. Frank Baum, The Art of Decorating Dry Goods Windows and Interiors (1900)*

What It Means Now

A broken link, a typo in the headline, a product image squashed on a phone, a footer still showing a copyright year from three years ago. Each one is small, and each one tells the visitor that nobody is minding the shop. On a page asking for money or an email address, that doubt is expensive.

The visitors most likely to spot these flaws are the careful ones reading every line before they buy. They are also the ones closest to buying. A regular check of your own pages, on a phone and on a slow connection, catches most of what they would otherwise find for you.

Then	Now
A pin showing in the drapery	A typo, a broken link or a squashed image
"No one will notice that"	"It looks fine on my laptop"
The careful observer at the glass	The visitor reading every line before buying

In Practice: A checkout page

Before: "Secure checkout" above a padlock icon, a returns link that led to an error page, and a footer reading "© 2021".

After: The same page with the returns link fixed and the footer year brought up to date.

Neither change took five minutes. Both were being noticed by exactly the visitors who were about to pay.

The Verdict: More important now than it was then

If anything, this matters more online than it ever did on paper. The internet has raised both the rewards for getting it right and the penalties for getting it wrong.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Small flaws cost trust, and trust is what the page is selling.*

Try This

- Run a free broken-link checker over your site
- Read your three most visited pages aloud, on a phone
- Load your checkout on a slow mobile connection and note anything that jumps or breaks

Chapter 7: What Goes in the Window

Space in a window was limited and valuable, so choosing what went into it was a business decision before it was a design one. The advice from the trade was specific about which goods earned the space. As L. Frank Baum explained in *The Art of Decorating Dry Goods Windows and Interiors* (1900):

> *In the selection of goods for your window two classes are best. First, new goods, of which there is ample stock; for, being new and seasonable, they are in demand and can be sold with profit and the money reinvested. Second, old goods which must be disposed of, probably at a sacrifice, in order that the money tied up in them may be used to better advantage. These last are "bargain" windows and each article must bear its price ticket. Cut the price sufficiently to interest people. Bear in mind that these goods might lie on your shelves years without moving if there was no show window to dispose of them. Properly displayed and properly priced, the show window will sell them like hot cakes, even though they are old enough to have gray whiskers. People dearly love bargains.*
>
> *— L. Frank Baum, The Art of Decorating Dry Goods Windows and Interiors (1900)*

What It Means Now

The top of a home page, the first email of the month and the pinned post on a social profile are the shop windows of an online business, and the same kinds of goods still earn them. New products that are in stock and in season bring in full-price sales. Old stock that has to go, clearly priced, turns dead inventory back into cash.

The season matters as well. What a visitor wants in January is not what they wanted in November, and a home page that never changes tells returning customers there is nothing new to see. A simple calendar of what to feature each month does most of the work.

Then	Now
New, seasonable goods with ample stock	Featured new products at full price
Old goods, each with its price ticket	A clearance page with clear prices
January sales of staples	Seasonal campaigns planned on a merchandising calendar

In Practice: An outdoor-gear shop in January

Before: The same summer tent banner that has been up since June.

After: Waterproofs and thermal layers at the top, with a strip beneath reading “Last season’s tents, 30% off”.

Two kinds of window on one screen: the goods people want this month, and the goods the shop needs to sell.

The Verdict: Still true — but the channel has changed

The principle holds, but it has moved house. Apply it where your readers are now, on screens and in feeds and inboxes, rather than where they were when it was written.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Give your best space to what is new or what must go, and change it with the season.*

Try This

- Note what sits at the top of your home page now, and when it last changed
- Plan the featured product for each of the next three months
- Create a clearance page with a clear price on every item

Conclusion: Old Rules, New Screens

Of the seven principles in this book, one has survived untouched, three still hold but have moved to new channels and three matter more now than they did then. That is a remarkable record for advice written before the first website, the first search engine or the first social feed.

The reason is simple. The media have changed beyond recognition, but the people at the other end of them have not. They are still busy, still sceptical, still looking for something that will make their lives a little better — and still willing to stop for a moment when someone speaks to them clearly, honestly and about the thing they care about.

The window dressers quoted here learned that lesson one window at a time, with the stock and the glass paid for up front. You can learn it faster, and test it more cheaply, than any of them could have dreamed. Start with one principle, one page and one change this week. Then come back for the next.

Your Action Plan

Work through one chapter a week. Each list below is small enough to finish in an afternoon, and each item produces something you can measure.

Week 1: Catch Your Hare First

- Open your main page on a phone and note what is visible before you scroll
- Rewrite the top headline so it names the visitor's problem, not your company
- Remove any rotating banner and keep its single strongest slide

Week 2: Fewer Things, Better Shown

- Count the separate links and buttons on your home page, then cut the number by a third
- Pick one product to feature this month and give it the top of the page
- Add white space around your main button

Week 3: Pretty Is Not the Point

- Check that your body text is at least 16 pixels on a phone
- Run your text and background colours through a free contrast checker
- Ask someone who has never seen the page to find the price and the buy button, and time them

Week 4: Let the Goods Tell a Story

- For your best-selling product, add one photo of it in use
- Record a phone video, under a minute long, of the product doing its main job
- Ask three customers for a photo of the product in their home or workplace

Week 5: Where the Eye Lands First

- Blur a screenshot of your page and note the first three shapes you notice
- Use your strongest colour for one thing only: the main button
- Shrink or soften anything that competes with the headline

Week 6: Somebody Always Notices

- Run a free broken-link checker over your site
- Read your three most visited pages aloud, on a phone
- Load your checkout on a slow mobile connection and note anything that jumps or breaks

Week 7: What Goes in the Window

- Note what sits at the top of your home page now, and when it last changed
- Plan the featured product for each of the next three months
- Create a clearance page with a clear price on every item

Glossary

Above the fold — The part of a web page visible without scrolling, named after the top half of a folded newspaper.

Bounce rate — The share of visitors who leave after viewing a single page, without clicking anything else.

Broken link — A link that leads to a missing page or an error, usually because the page it pointed to was moved or deleted.

Conversion rate — The share of visitors who complete the action a page is built for, such as buying or signing up.

Lifestyle photo — A product image that shows the item in a real setting, being used, rather than alone on a plain background.

Merchandising calendar — A plan of which products or offers a business will feature in each week or month of the year.

Visual hierarchy — The order in which the eye notices elements on a page, set by size, colour, contrast and position.

Sources & Notes

The historical passages quoted in this book are reproduced from public domain editions of the following works. Spelling and punctuation are the original authors'; only the typography (dashes and quotation marks) has been modernised.

- Edmund G. Gress, *The Art & Practice of Typography* (1917)
- L. Frank Baum, *The Art of Decorating Dry Goods Windows and Interiors* (1900)

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